WEATHERING THE STORM

A GUIDE TO BUILDING RESILIENT TEAMS

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CHAPTER ONE:

CREATING TEAM/ ORGANISATIONAL PURPOSE

What you will gain from this chapter

A deeper understanding of the significance of purpose in driving team resilience and organisational success.

Insights into what defines a purpose-driven organisation and real-world examples of companies that have successfully integrated purpose into their strategies.

Knowledge of how purpose contributes to intrinsic motivation, team cohesion, and adaptability in the face of challenges.

A practical, step-by-step approach to crafting a compelling team purpose statement that aligns with the broader organisational mission.

Strategies for effective communication, strategic alignment, and fostering a sense of ownership among employees in the pursuit of a purpose-driven culture.

An appreciation for the importance of encouraging employees to explore and align their purposes with the organisation's purpose, leading to heightened engagement and a stronger connection between individuals and the collective mission.

Insight: Your team's why

The concept of purpose has gained popularity both in business and personal spheres. After getting her master's degree my daughter was discussing her career goals with me. She realised how important it was to have a clear sense of purpose when making long-term decisions. While I recognised the value of understanding one's purpose, I have always stressed the beauty of not feeling confined to having all the answers before taking action. Life, much like a captivating story, has a way of unveiling facets of our purpose as we navigate its twists and turns. Reflecting on my story, I came to an understanding of my own purpose after leaving the business world; a statement that changed the focus of my career was "unlocking human potential." This purpose became clear to me as I retraced the steps of my two-decade career in sales. Although crafting sales strategies and spearheading initiatives brought a sense of accomplishment, it was the human connection that was a part of my job that really resonated with me. It made me happy to understand what made each person unique, to identify their latent talents, and to nurture their growth. And so, the phrase "unlocking human potential" etched itself as the cornerstone of my purpose.

As the crossroads of my post-corporate journey approached, the idea of becoming a coach emerged, blatantly clear that it fits with my purpose. The unique responsibility of a coach, which involves helping people reach their full potential, pushed me to undertake new training. What started as a quest to help people reach their full potential grew into a bigger mission: to help leaders and teams become more resilient. This newfound interest, which I discovered while working with clients, helped me write this book. Each page is a testament to the evolution of my purpose - developing from unlocking individual potential to cultivating resilience within teams and leaders.

While discussions about purpose-led organisations abound, especially in attracting millennial and Gen Z talent, it is noteworthy that a sense of purpose also contributes to employee engagement and retention. These positive aspects enhance both individual and organisational value. I believe that the primary reason for an organisation to adopt a purpose-driven

approach is to cultivate resilience, enabling not just survival but thriving and ensuring sustainability. Julie Kapsalis, CEO and Principal at North East Surrey College of Technology (NESCOT) emphasises the importance of a shared sense of purpose. She questions whether the motivation for hard work stems from external factors like achieving a certain accreditation or from a genuine belief in the fundamental mission of providing the best education and destinations for her students. Julie sees a shared purpose within her leadership team as a powerful motivator for going the extra mile and achieving their goals. Their ambition to move from a "good" to an "outstanding" rating in the next Ofsted inspection is not driven by trying to 'peak' for the inspection but by a deep commitment to ensuring every student receives the best education and opportunities every single day. In exploring purpose-driven organisations, it becomes crucial to understand what defines them, how their purpose manifests, and why it contributes to resilience. Equally important is the exploration of how to create a purpose-driven culture. These are the questions I explore within this chapter.

What is a purpose-driven organisation?

While the significance of purpose-led companies is widely acknowledged in today's business landscape, a universally accepted definition remains elusive. Various authors diverge in their emphasis, with one group focusing on a company's product and brand values, echoing Accenture's view that function is "the reason for something's existence." Another perspective centres on the broader environmental and social impact of a company, aligning closely with environmental, social, and governance (ESG) concepts. A compelling definition proposed by Henderson and van den Steen (2015) defines a company's purpose as "a concrete goal or objective that goes beyond maximising profits." This goes further than specific activities like donations or sponsorships, encapsulating the core "raison d'être" of a company, guiding all of its activities and acting as its core philosophy.

Illustratively, TOMS, a shoe and eyewear company, integrates its purpose, "we believe in a more equitable world," by giving a third of its profits for grassroots good. Their strategy aligns with their purpose through the use of sustainable materials, ethical

sourcing, fair labour practices, and employee participation in social impact initiatives. Regular impact reporting underscores their commitment to transparency. Similarly, Microsoft, with its purpose to "empower every person and every organisation on the planet to achieve more," successfully navigated the pandemic by facilitating remote work and online education. Their focus on employee well-being and mental health showcased a purpose-driven approach that guided strategic decisions and adaptation to changing circumstances. This commitment to social responsibility contributed to increased revenue and stock value. And finally, Moderna, a biotechnology company, thrived during the pandemic due to its purpose-driven mission to deliver impact through mRNA medicines. The rapid development of a highly efficacious COVID-19 vaccine showcased their commitment to innovation and science. A purpose-driven culture fostered collaboration, risk-taking, and resilience - crucial attributes during unprecedented challenges. Moderna's unwavering commitment to societal impact positioned it as a thriving entity during the pandemic and beyond. Table 1 further displays some other examples of company purpose statements.

Table 1: Purpose statements of companies

Company	Purpose Statement
Unilever	To make sustainable living commonplace
GlaxoSmithKline	Do more, feel better, live longer
Rolls-Royce	To pioneer the power that matters
Vodafone	Connecting for a better future
Tesco	To create value for customers to earn their lifetime loyalty
Disney	To entertain, inform and inspire people around the globe through the power of unparalleled storytelling
Patagonia	We're in business to save our home planet
Airbus	We pioneer sustainable aerospace for a safe and united world
Philips	To improve people's health and well-being through meaningful innovation

Having a sense of purpose in your business goes beyond mere numerical metrics, sales figures, and profits. Mike England, CEO of Flowtech Plc, reflects on his personal experience at RS Group plc, underscoring the crucial role of a shared purpose in cultivating resilience at both individual and organisational levels. According to Mike, there exists a meaningful connection between individual resilience, team resilience, and business resilience, with a sense of purpose being integral to each. He emphasises that ever since he discovered his purpose, a compelling and motivating force, he has actively encouraged his teams to uncover their purposes too. Mike contends that

awareness of purpose and alignment with the company's broader mission are essential for engaging teams and equipping them to navigate challenges and overcome setbacks.

Consider the rowing team that I coached, embarking on the ambitious journey to circumnavigate Great Britain, a formidable 2,000 mile journey, with the aspiration of setting a world record. Although the team encountered unforeseen challenges, requiring a rescue operation only 500 miles into the endeavour, their journey held a more profound purpose than the mere pursuit of a record. In essence, the rowing team was a contributor to a greater cause by providing valuable climate change data for a University of Portsmouth study. This shift from their original sporting goal underscores the importance of fostering a purpose that goes beyond specific key performance indicators (KPIs) or narrowly defined objectives, ultimately broadening individuals' perspectives. While the team may have fallen short of completing the circumnavigation, the first 500 miles of their trip were very important to the broader story of climate change research. This parallel focus underscores the resilience and adaptability required in the face of unforeseen challenges, ultimately allowing the team to make a tangible and meaningful impact where it was least expected. Despite the setback, their addition to climate change data shows the power of purpose-driven efforts, showing that even when things seem to fail, success can be found when aligned with a purpose that goes beyond set goals.

Tesla, renowned for electric cars and Elon Musk, epitomises a purpose-driven approach. While many associate Tesla with being the leading provider of electric cars, their mission, "accelerating the world's transition to sustainable energy," surpasses the scope of vehicle manufacturing. Regardless of one's role at Tesla, whether in manufacturing, sales, or finance, employees contribute to a global cause, actively participating in an initiative to expedite the world's adoption of renewable energy. In a thorough examination of the extended performance of companies driven by purpose compared to those primarily fixated on sales and profits, the book 'Firms of Endearment' conducted a study spanning a decade (2002 to 2012). The findings showed that companies propelled by purpose, stakeholder orientation, and a robust caring culture, consistently outperformed their counterparts driven solely by sales and

profits. Purpose-driven companies achieved an impressive annual average return on equity of 13.1%, significantly outpacing the 4.12% return of companies focused primarily on sales and profits. This stark contrast in performance underscores the tangible financial benefits of adopting a purpose-led approach to business. Essentially, integrating a purpose into business operations proves to be a catalyst for success, influencing performance on multiple levels and ultimately contributing to sustained profitability.

How does this connect to cultivating team resilience?

In March 2020, the UK government's announcement about the onset of the coronavirus pandemic and the subsequent lockdown plunged us into a realm of unknowns. It was a global shockwave, leaving individuals and organisations grappling with a chaotic state of not knowing what lay ahead. There was no playbook, no roadmap for individuals or leaders to follow. With all of this uncertainty, I found myself consulting with CEOs, some of whom were clients, who were battling with the profound impacts of the unfolding events.

One such CEO reached out to me, seeking advice on how to navigate the pandemic. It was during this that a fundamental question emerged: "What is the purpose of your business?" This CEO led a purpose-driven organisation, and as he reiterated the company's purpose, it sparked the question: "Has the pandemic altered your purpose in any way?" His response was "Not really." I said, "Okay, while the fundamental purpose remains unchanged, the 'how' and the 'timing' might have shifted in how you are going to achieve it." It became apparent that revisiting the team, reinforcing the purpose, and using it as a source of energy to generate ideas were essential steps to steer through the challenges posed by the pandemic. Thinking about this advice, the CEO led his team in a useful exercise. By revisiting their purpose, they breathed new life into their collective enthusiasm. Energised by the shared sense of purpose, the team embarked on a collaborative journey to devise strategies that would not only address the uncertainties brought about by the pandemic but also keep them aligned with their overarching mission.

This narrative vividly illustrates the transformative power of a well-defined purpose in guiding a team through the challenges within their organisation. By taking a step back and gaining perspective from the broader picture outlined by their purpose, the team found themselves better equipped to address and navigate complexities effectively. It showcases the resilience and adaptability that a purpose-driven approach can instil, serving as both a compass and a source of inspiration during times of change and uncertainty.

Why does purpose play a crucial role in fostering team resilience?

As an example, let's consider a team within Unilever, the global consumer goods company, guided by the purpose "to make sustainable living commonplace." Unlike the fleeting allure of external rewards, intrinsic motivation draws strength from deep internal desires, values, and a profound sense of purpose. This exploration shows the synergy between purpose and intrinsic motivation, highlighting the impact of purpose as a guiding light that leads teams toward resilience. In this context, the team's purpose revolves around advancing Unilever's mission to promote sustainable living practices worldwide.

As the team works towards reducing environmental impact or developing sustainable product lines, purpose-driven work transcends isolated tasks, presenting itself as an integral part of a larger, purposeful journey. Intrinsic fulfilment becomes a powerful force propelling team members through difficulties, anchoring them in a sense of purpose beyond daily challenges. Connecting with Unilever's mission encourages a commitment to making sustainable living commonplace, acting as a secure foundation during challenging times. Integrating intrinsic motivation with ownership and autonomy leads to a proactive response to challenges. For instance, team members may actively engage in initiatives such as reducing carbon emissions or implementing eco-friendly packaging, driven by a belief in Unilever's purpose, and desire to see that fulfilled.

Unilever's purpose sparks emotional investment, encouraging team members to be stewards of their contributions. This emotional connection becomes a source of resilience,

motivating individuals to rise above adversity when faced with obstacles. For instance, encountering supply chain disruptions or market fluctuations prompts the team to use their emotional connections to Unilever's purpose, seeking innovative solutions and collaborative strategies to continue making sustainable living commonplace. Purpose-driven individuals see challenges as opportunities for development, viewing setbacks as valuable learning experiences contributing to personal and collective growth. This perspective often aligns with personal aspirations, reinforcing the team's commitment to Unilever's mission.

A north star

A purpose is the north star; it acts as a compass, directing individuals' actions and decisions, especially during stormy weather. The purpose is why people want to work together, collaborate, and achieve a shared goal. All parties come together around this one main reason for being. While core values are guardrails for how people make decisions and behave, the purpose defines the why. Teams are often busy delivering their work with little idea of why they're doing it – having a clear purpose increases motivation and engagement.

Consider the example of the CEO whom I had the privilege of coaching during the challenging times brought about by the global pandemic. Faced with unprecedented uncertainties, this leader recognised the pivotal role of purpose in guiding their team through the storm. By articulating a team purpose that resonated with the values and aspirations of its members, they instilled a sense of meaning into the collective efforts. This purpose became a rallying point during the pandemic, aligning the team's energies toward a common objective.

The CEO's commitment to a team purpose proved instrumental in maintaining high motivation and resilience. Team members felt a stronger connection to their work, understanding not just what they were doing but why it mattered. This, in turn, created a subculture within the broader organisational context, where the team's purpose became a source of inspiration and cohesion. The experience of this CEO underscores the importance of not only having an overarching organisational purpose, but also crafting a distinct team purpose. While

the company's purpose provides direction, a team purpose connects individuals with a profound sense of significance, fostering a deeper understanding of the collective "why." In essence, the strategic design of a team purpose unites team members in purposeful endeavours even during the most challenging circumstances.

During a recent workshop with a client's team, the power of uncovering their team's purpose became evident. Guiding them through a series of introspective exercises and discussions, the team came together around a shared purpose that supported their collective values and aspirations. Witnessing this process unfold was truly impactful, as team members transitioned from individual contributors to a united force with a common mission. The newfound clarity of purpose added a renewed sense of motivation and commitment within the team. The impact could be seen through their daily tasks, transforming routine activities into meaningful contributions towards a larger goal. Notably, the team's enhanced cohesion and intrinsic motivation translated into improved performance, innovation, and a shared sense of accomplishment. This experience showed how aligning a team with a purpose can create positive change, strengthening their collective resilience and propelling them towards sustained success.

Adaptability

Purpose-driven teams are inherently more inclined to embrace change and navigate uncertainties with resilience. The purpose acts as a guide, infusing every challenge with a sense of purpose that goes beyond the current obstacles. This, in turn, creates a culture where adaptability is not merely a reactive response but a proactive stance, a strategic tool used by teams to stay aligned with their greater mission. Teams, motivated by a shared sense of purpose, become hotbeds for creative thinking and problem-solving. The purpose acts as a catalyst, encouraging team members to explore novel ideas, challenge the status quo, and approach challenges with a fresh perspective. To conclude purpose not only inspires teams to weather change but also propels them to proactively shape their path amid uncertainties.

How to define your team/organisation's purpose:

Crafting purpose statements involves articulating the team's objectives and the positive influence it aspires to have. A particularly effective and easily facilitated method for formulating a team's purpose can be broken down into two parts.

Part 1 – Defining why the team exists:

» Defining your team's role:

Generate a concise sentence encapsulating the fundamental function or output of your team. Encourage team members to contribute multiple ideas, group them based on commonalities, and rank them in order of significance. If your team engages in diverse activities, try to distil a unifying concept that best represents the majority of your work. For instance, "We streamline supply chain processes to ensure timely and efficient product delivery" or "We provide personalised financial consulting to help clients achieve their financial goals."

» Identifying our key stakeholders:

List the various groups or stakeholders your team serves and pinpoint the primary one. Specify whether your assistance spans broadly across senior executives or is more department-specific, such as sales or marketing. Clarify if your focus is on a particular department or the entire organisation.

» Envisioning impact:

Explore the purpose of your team by understanding the challenges and benefits experienced by your primary stakeholders. Explore how your team can contribute to their success and, most crucially, articulate the ultimate impact you aim to achieve in their lives, extending beyond functional contributions. For instance, "Empowering our managers to lead with confidence" or "Equipping advisors to elevate client satisfaction."

Part 2 – Write your team purpose statement:

Formulate a statement based on "Our team (insert what you do) to/for (insert specific audience) so that (insert intended impact)."

» Examples of purpose statements:

"Our team streamlines the food manufacturing supply chain for the timely delivery of quality products, ensuring a seamless and reliable food supply chain."

"We create compelling marketing content to guide individuals in navigating the complexities of wealth management, fostering financial literacy and confidence."

» Does everyone understand the purpose?

In the pursuit of establishing a purpose-driven team or organisation, effective communication and strategic alignment serve as foundational principles. From products and services to cultural elements and decision-making processes, every operational dimension should align with and contribute to the team or organisational purpose.

Tracy Aust, Principal at West Thames College, emphasises the importance of a shared goal and a common purpose that is understood by all team members. She also underscores the significance of trust, confidence, and diversity within the team, including those who may challenge or offer different perspectives, stating, "I think the whole aspect of having a shared goal and a common purpose that's understood by all is vital." This alignment establishes the groundwork for constructing a purpose-driven framework, ensuring that the entirety of your team or organisation functions in sync with its core mission.

Engaging employees in the purpose journey is equally vital. Developing a sense of ownership empowers them to actively contribute, increasing not just productivity but also levels of motivation, commitment, and job satisfaction. Communication becomes a linchpin in this process—sharing the purpose with clarity with internal and external stakeholders. Using effective

communication tools such as messaging, storytelling, and branding authenticates the purpose, creating a narrative that resonates with all involved. To truly measure the impact of a purpose-driven approach, robust mechanisms must be in place. Transparently communicating the outcomes of purpose-driven initiatives to stakeholders becomes an ongoing responsibility.

Lastly, the journey towards purpose is dynamic, requiring continuous evaluation and adaptation. Regular reviews ensure that the purpose aligns with evolving goals, values, and the external environment. Being open to necessary adjustments guarantees that the purpose remains not only relevant but also impactful and meaningful over time. Following these steps paves the way for a purpose-driven team or organisation that integrates its mission into its daily operations and culture.

It's important to recognise that not everyone's purpose aligns perfectly with the organisation. However, this process can bring clarity regarding the significance of their career and the company they choose to work for. When there's a broader alignment between personal and organisational purposes, it leads to heightened employee engagement. Encouraging this exploration not only contributes to the individual growth of employees but also strengthens the overall connection between individuals and the organisation.

Chapter summary

This chapter explores the concept of purpose-driven organisations and teams, emphasising the significance of having a clear and compelling purpose that goes beyond profit maximisation. It provides real-world examples and highlights the role of purpose in fostering team resilience, intrinsic motivation, cohesion, and adaptability. The chapter outlines a practical approach to defining a team's purpose, stressing the importance of effective communication, strategic alignment, and encouraging a sense of ownership among employees. Additionally, it underscores the value of encouraging employees to explore and align their purposes with the organisation's purpose, leading to heightened engagement and a stronger connection between individuals and the collective mission.

Reflection

How would you articulate your sense of purpose in your personal and professional life?

Reflect on a pivotal moment when your understanding of your purpose evolved. What did you learn about yourself?

Does your current workplace have a clearly defined purpose? How well do you think it aligns with your values and goals?

Reflect on a challenging period in your professional life. How did a sense of purpose or lack thereof impact your resilience and ability to navigate difficulties?

If you are in a leadership position, how have you or could you use your team's shared purpose to guide them during challenging times?

Can you think of specific actions or initiatives that could enhance a purpose-driven culture in your workplace?

Have you actively thought about your employees' or colleagues' individual purposes? How might understanding and supporting these individual purposes contribute to a more engaged and motivated team?

What resources or initiatives could your organisation provide to help employees discover and align with their purpose?

Do you feel a personal alignment between your purpose and the purpose of your organisation or team? If not, how might you seek or create alignment?

In your leadership role, how do you ensure that the organisation's purpose remains relevant and impactful over time?

Action

Craft a personal purpose statement that reflects your values, aspirations, and the impact you want to make in your personal and professional life.

Evaluate how well your current workplace aligns with your purpose. If there's misalignment, consider initiating a conversation with leadership to explore ways to better integrate personal and organisational purposes.

Propose or organise a team workshop to revisit and redefine the team's purpose. Discuss how the shared purpose can be a source of resilience during challenging times.

Initiate conversations with colleagues or team members about their purposes. Encourage open dialogue about personal aspirations and explore ways to align these with team and organisational goals.

Demonstrate your commitment to the team's purpose through your actions and decision-making. Be a role model for how purpose-driven leadership looks in practice.

If you're in a leadership position, prioritise leadership development programs that emphasise the role of purpose in guiding decisions, fostering resilience, and inspiring teams.

Working with Julian

Are you ready to build a more resilient team that can thrive in any environment? As the author of "Weathering the Storm: A Guide to Building Resilient Teams," I offer personalised coaching and consultation services to help you implement the strategies and principles outlined in this book.

» What I offer

One-on-One Executive Coaching: Tailored sessions to develop your leadership skills and enhance your ability to build and lead resilient teams.

Team Resilience Workshops: Interactive sessions designed to assess your team's current resilience and develop strategies for improvement.

Customised Resilience-Building Programmes: Long-term engagements to transform your team or organisation's culture and practices.

» My approach

I believe in a collaborative, evidence-based approach that combines the latest research with practical, real-world strategies. My methods are adaptable to your unique context and challenges, ensuring that you get solutions that work for your specific situation.

» What you can expect

Deep insights into team dynamics and organisational behaviour.

Practical tools and techniques for building resilience.

Ongoing support and accountability.

Measurable improvements in team performance and adaptability.

» Ready to weather any storm?

Contact me at julian@julianrobertsconsulting.com to discuss how we can work together to build your team's resilience and set you up for long-term success.

Remember, resilience isn't just about surviving - it's about thriving in the face of adversity. Let's embark on this journey together.